



The Birth of Dionysus

Semele was a priestess at a temple dedicated to Zeus. One day, after she had sacrificed a bull to the god, she went out swimming to wash off the blood.

Zeus happened to be flying overhead in the shape of an eagle, and when he spotted Semele, he immediately fell madly in love. He changed into a mortal shape to speak to her.

Semele was very pleased to have the attention of the god she had worshiped for so many years.

When Semele learned she was pregnant with Zeus's child, she was overjoyed, as was Zeus. "Dearest Semele," he said, "I love you so much. I swear on the Styx River that you can ask me for anything and I will give it to you."